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STUDENT HANDOUT

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GO DEEPER

Coin Detectives

Grades 3–4 · Real or Replica?

ADMIT ONE

NAME _____ DATE _____ CLASS _____

The coins in *In Their Hands* were spent and held in the years of the Gospels. Eight are genuine. Three are museum-quality replicas, honest copies labeled as copies. But how does an expert know an ancient coin is real? Today you are a coin detective.

01

PART 1

Detective report: the hardest fake

One of these drachms is genuine. The other is a *die transfer* fake: the faker made a mold from a real coin's die and struck a new coin with it. The design looks right at first glance. Weigh the evidence below: is each clue **strong** or **weak**?

REAL OR REPLICA? · GREEK DRACHM



COIN A



COIN B

EVIDENCE	STRONG OR WEAK?	WHY?
The design looks correct		
One coin looks flatter and grayer		
One coin has sharper details		
Tests show one coin's metal is the wrong mix		

02

PART 2

Your verdict

The fake is Coin (A) or Coin (B) (circle one)

Give your two strongest pieces of evidence. Then explain what an expert could do to be completely sure.

03

PART 3

Why does it matter?

The Tribute Penny, the Shekel of Tyre and the coin of Herod Antipas are replicas, because real ones are so rare. Each is labeled as a replica. How is a replica different from a fake? Why is Pilate's genuine coin stronger evidence than a replica?

04

PART 4

Order and explain

Write **1 to 5** in the boxes, from the coin made first to the coin made last.



Herod Agrippa I
41–44 AD



Widow's Mite
103–76 BC



Porcius Festus
59–62 AD



Augustus Caesar
5–4 BC



Pontius Pilate
29/30 AD

The widow's mite was made long before the others. But the widow gave her two coins in Jesus' last week in Jerusalem, long after Augustus. How can both be true? What does this teach a detective about the date on a coin?

SHARE WITH YOUR FAMILY

Ask your family: what makes a museum trustworthy? Tell them how the exhibition labels its replicas, and how Pilate's coin was evidence before anyone found his stone.